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Original Page: 39**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** June 1967-April 1969**Coverage Date:** 1963-1973**Place Coverage:** Dobe Area, Botswana**Section Title(S):** Assessing The Age Estimates

Kasupe is estimated to have been born in 1912, the oldest child of a mother who must have been around 75 in 1968. Unfortunately she lives across the border at the settlement station of Chum!kwe, and we have no photo of her. She is, however, the mother of one of the main informants of the Marshall family's studies of the !Kung Bushmen, called "old N/aoka" (Marshall 1976:xxii).

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The Marshall family's expedition to a nearby area to study !Kung in the 1950s provides one more opportunity to test the plausibility of the estimation procedure. Elizabeth Marshall Thomas (1959:165) writes of the adventures of the imperious young woman, "beautiful Unkha, the lily of the field," who seemed in 1955 to be such a strange combination of a playful and rather silly child and a beautiful woman who could use her power over her husband and other men to tease and humiliate them. Although I had read *The Harmless People* before going to the field, I did not realize until I returned to my book collection that "beautiful Unkha" was the same person with whom I had shared a pleasant friendship at /Xai/xai in 1967-1968, trading gifts and favors and continually joking about trading husbands. She had been married for many years to a different husband than the one described in *The Harmless People*, had four healthy children and was a competent adult member of the community. Figure 2.5 permits us to look backward in time at the picture taken by John Marshall in 1955 to see if the aging process for at least this one woman is consistent with the ages we estimate people to be in 1968. Figure 2.5 shows the original picture from 1955, when she must have been 17 according to my age estimates, her picture in 1968 at the age of 30, and the pictures of some girls in the 1968 population who are estimated to be the same age in 1968 that "beautiful Unkha" was in 1955.

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These kinds of "tests" of the plausibility of the method of estimation provide no solid basis for assessing the range of probable error in the estimates. The amount of error in estimation for any one person depends in part on the source of the error in the steps of the procedure. Wrong placement in the rank order, for instance, probably contributes to the largest errors for individual adults, although the ranking procedure itself seems to be the strongest feature of the procedure in reducing errors overall. If a person doesn't know his rank relative to the others in the area, or gives answers to the ranking placement which are obviously wrong (to him) due to "joking" relations with particular others, the individual error could be as large as 10 years for adults or old people. Another source of errors in the final estimates is problems with combining the four distinct age ranks into one: If the age structure of the four areas is actually rather different, combining them mechanically into one rank will introduce systematic errors. Finally, the choice of a curve-fitting technique can be a source of error. The technique used here assumes regular production (and maintenance) of people in each age group, 40

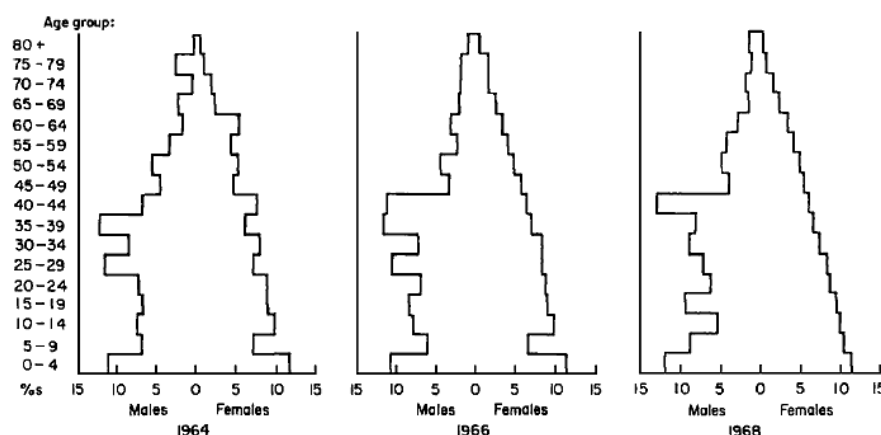
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Composition Of
Population

Figure 2.6. Age-sex pyramids, for resident populations of 1964, 1966, and 1968.



41 with no annual variation or annual variation that averages out into a smooth curve. Consider the effects of a run of good weather, good food supply, or simply good luck that produces twice as many surviving infants in one year as expected: Everyone older than those infants would be pushed up a year in age, and what is good luck from the !Kung perspective is disastrous for the age estimation procedure. Similarly, a run of bad luck that produced no surviving infants in a year would pull everyone older down a year in age. In a population so small that only about 15 infants are expected to be born each year, random or systematic fluctuations in births and deaths will be expected to introduce continuous errors of as much as several years in individual ages.

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